



Ages 14 to 18

Control, Coercion and Healthy Relationships

What controlling and coercive behaviour is, what the law says, and what you can do. For all students.

Before You Read This guide covers controlling relationships, threats and abuse.

This guide is about controlling and coercive behaviour in relationships and friendships, including threats and image-based abuse. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with something that has happened to you or someone close to you.

- Read it in sections, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free and confidential, any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.
- **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258, free, 24/7.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

This guide is for **all students**. It explains what controlling and coercive behaviour is, what the law says, how to help a friend, and what to do if it's happening to you.

- It happens in **relationships**, and in **friendships and groups** too.
- **Anyone** can experience it: girls and boys, in same-sex and mixed relationships, whatever their background.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**. If you recognise it in your own behaviour, you can change it.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.

- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline**: 0800 1111, free, any time.

Key Words

Healthy relationship

Trust, respect, freedom to be yourself and see other people, and being able to disagree or end it without fear.

Controlling behaviour

Trying to make someone dependent or isolated: deciding who they see, what they wear, where they go, or checking their phone.

Coercive behaviour

Threats, humiliation, intimidation or guilt used to make someone do what you want, or to scare them.

Coercive control

A pattern of controlling and coercive behaviour over time. It can be abuse even without any violence.

Gaslighting

Making someone doubt their own memory or feelings:
"That never happened."
"You're overreacting."

Image-based abuse

Sharing, or threatening to share, intimate images without consent, including fake or AI-made images.

Healthy or Controlling?

Healthy

- You see your friends and family without having to ask
- Your phone, passwords and location are yours
- You wear what you want and keep doing what you enjoy
- You can say no, disagree, or end it, without fear

Controlling

- They decide who you can see or message
- They check your phone, demand passwords or track your location

- They make rules about what you wear or where you go
- They threaten to leave, to hurt themselves, or to share something, if you don't comply
- You feel scared of their reaction, or like you're walking on eggshells

"They're Just Jealous"

Everyone feels jealous sometimes. Control is different: it's a **pattern** of limiting and monitoring someone. It isn't proof of love, and it often gets worse over time. **A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before asking for help.**

What the Data Shows

28%

of 13 to 17 year olds had been in a relationship in the past year

Youth Endowment Fund, 2025
(10,835 13 to 17 year olds)

36%

of those in a relationship had experienced emotionally abusive or controlling behaviour

Youth Endowment Fund, 2025
(10,835 13 to 17 year olds)

19%

of those in a relationship had a partner check their phone or social media

YEF, 2025

14%

had their location monitored by a partner

YEF, 2025

Girls and boys both experience it: 41% of girls and 37% of boys who had been in a relationship had experienced emotional or physical abuse. Checked September 2026.

Sources: check them yourself

- Youth Endowment Fund, *Children, Violence and Vulnerability 2025*: violence in relationships (survey of 10,835 13 to 17 year olds, May to July 2025)
- Youth Endowment Fund, *One in every classroom* (December 2025)

What the Law Says

England and Wales

- **The definition of domestic abuse** covers people who are both 16 or over and are, or were, in a relationship or family, whether or not they live together. It can be a single incident or a pattern.
- **The criminal law is separate from that definition.** Controlling or coercive behaviour between partners, ex-partners or family members can be a crime when it is repeated and has a serious effect. Whether a crime has been committed depends on what happened, not only on age. In England and Wales, criminal responsibility starts at 10.
- **If you're younger, or it's a friendship**, it is still abuse, adults will act to keep you safe, and some behaviour can still be a crime.
- **Sexual images** of anyone under 18, including realistic AI-made images, and threats to share intimate images, can involve criminal offences. Adults will treat them as a safeguarding matter first.

If you're being controlled, you won't be in trouble for asking for help. Schools respond to this as a safeguarding matter: their job is to keep you safe.

Online Control

- **Constant messages and instant-reply rules** are a way of keeping tabs on you.
- **Location sharing** should be your choice, and you should be able to turn it off without trouble.
- **Passwords are private.** Sharing them isn't proof of trust.
- **If someone threatens to share an image:** don't send more, don't pay, and tell an adult. Don't screenshot or forward nude images, even as evidence.
- **Report Remove** (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation) can help get a nude image of you removed if you are under 18. **CEOP** (ceop.police.uk) is for reporting online sexual abuse.
- **Plan before changing things.** Suddenly blocking someone or turning off location can make a controlling person angrier. A trusted adult can help you plan it safely.

RESPOND: What You Can Do

Young people often tell a friend before they tell an adult. That makes you part of how people get help. RESPOND has three parts for students: **you lead the relational steps**, **Pause is the bridge**, and **adults lead the systems steps**.

Relational: You Lead (R, E, S)

R Recognise

Notice the pattern.

- Is your friend dropping friends or activities, or anxious about their phone?
- Use the 4 Ps: **People** (who has the power?), **Places** (where?), **Platforms** (online?), **Patterns** (is it repeated, and getting worse?)
- You don't need certainty to act

E Engage

Make contact. Listen.

- "I've noticed you don't come out any more. Are you OK?"
- Listen without criticising the other person: that can make your friend defend them
- **If you see it happening**, the safest options are usually to **Delegate** (get a trusted adult), **Distract** (give your friend a reason to leave with you) and **Delay** (check in privately afterwards). Speaking up directly is an option only if you can do it safely, without confronting anyone or getting physically involved: a public challenge can lead to trouble for your friend once you've gone

S Support

Stay close.

- "I'm here for you. We can speak to someone you trust together, and you don't have to work this out on your own."
- Keep including them. Isolation is how control works; friendship pushes back

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Slow down before you act.

- Three questions: **Risk** (is anyone in danger?), **Rights** (what does my friend need?), **Resources** (who can help?)
- Don't confront the controlling person, investigate, or promise to keep it secret
- You're not expected to monitor anyone, collect evidence or manage the situation yourself. That is the adults' job

Systems: Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Model alternatives. Signpost help.

- Tell your friend help is available, and offer to go with them
- Model what healthy looks like: trust, respect, freedom



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- If you're worried, tell a trusted adult promptly, **even if your friend asks you not to**. Tell your friend what you're going to do, if you can
- If there are threats of violence, self-harm or sharing images, tell an adult straight away
- It isn't betraying them. It's how they get protected



Document

Adults record it.

- The adult makes the formal record. Tell them clearly what you saw and heard

If It's Happening to You

It's Not Your Fault

- Nobody deserves to be controlled, whatever they did or said.
- You can tell any adult you trust, at any time, even if you're not sure it's "bad enough" or you still care about the person.
- If the first person you tell doesn't help, tell someone else.

If You Want to End It

- Ending a controlling relationship can be the time the other person reacts most. You don't have to do it alone.
- A trusted adult can help you plan: when, how, and what happens at school afterwards.
- If you feel in danger, call 999.

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with a person you trust. Behind them is a system:** a safeguarding team, records and procedures that make sure what you tell one person reaches the people who can help. The person is why young people tell; the system is why telling works.
- You'll be listened to and taken seriously. Adults won't confront the other person without a plan to keep you safe.
- The adult will pass it to the safeguarding team. They won't promise to keep it secret, and they'll tell you what they are doing.
- The law allows schools to share information needed to keep a young person safe without asking for consent, and from 30 September 2026 a new legal duty requires many safeguarding organisations to share it. What is shared must be relevant and proportionate, go only to the people who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Because your consent isn't the legal basis, they won't ask for it as if it were. They should tell you what they are sharing, with whom and why, unless that would put someone at risk, and listen to what you think. Agreeing to support, such as counselling, is a separate choice, and your views matter there.
- You'll have as much say as possible in the plan and the support you get.

Whoever You Are

- LGBTQ+ young people can face control through threats to "out" them. Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111.
- No one should control you through "rules" about culture, religion or family honour. If you're worried about pressure to marry, or honour-based abuse, tell a trusted adult. Karma Nirvana (honour-based abuse and forced marriage): 0800 5999 247 (Monday to Friday 9am to 5pm).
- Boys can be controlled too, and deserve the same help.

If You're Worried About Your Own Behaviour

If you recognise yourself in this guide, noticing it is the first step. Jealousy, anxiety or anger can drive controlling behaviour, and people can change with the right help.

- Talk to an adult you trust at school.
- **Respect Phoneline:** 0808 802 4040 (Monday to Friday 10am to 5pm), for anyone worried about their own behaviour in a relationship.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) is there for you too.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"Jealousy shows they love you"	Controlling behaviour is a warning sign, not proof of love.
"It's not abuse if they've never hit you"	Coercive control can be abuse without any violence.
"It only happens in relationships"	It happens in friendships and groups too.
"Boys can't be controlled"	Boys and young men experience controlling behaviour too, and deserve support.

"Just block them and it'll stop"

Sudden changes can make things worse.
Plan it with a trusted adult.

"Telling an adult makes it worse"

Adults will make a plan with you before
anyone speaks to the other person.

If You Board

- **You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.**
- If the person controlling you is in your house, tell a house parent. Changes should be planned so that you don't carry the burden.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor or advisor, your head of year, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19):** 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.**
- **Shout:** text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Love Respect (Women's Aid):** loversrespect.co.uk, information and a relationship quiz for young people

- **Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25):** if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111
- If you're 18 or over: Galop National LGBT+ Domestic Abuse Helpline (18 and over): 0800 999 5428 (Monday and Tuesday 9:15am to 8pm, Wednesday to Friday 9:15am to 4:30pm)
- **Emergency:** call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Control, Coercion and Healthy Relationships: Student Guide 46 - 14 to 18

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Contacts and figures checked September 2026 | Next review: September 2027